THE LAWS OF SOFTWARE TEAMS

# The Peter principle

## In a hierarchy, people rise to their level of incompetence

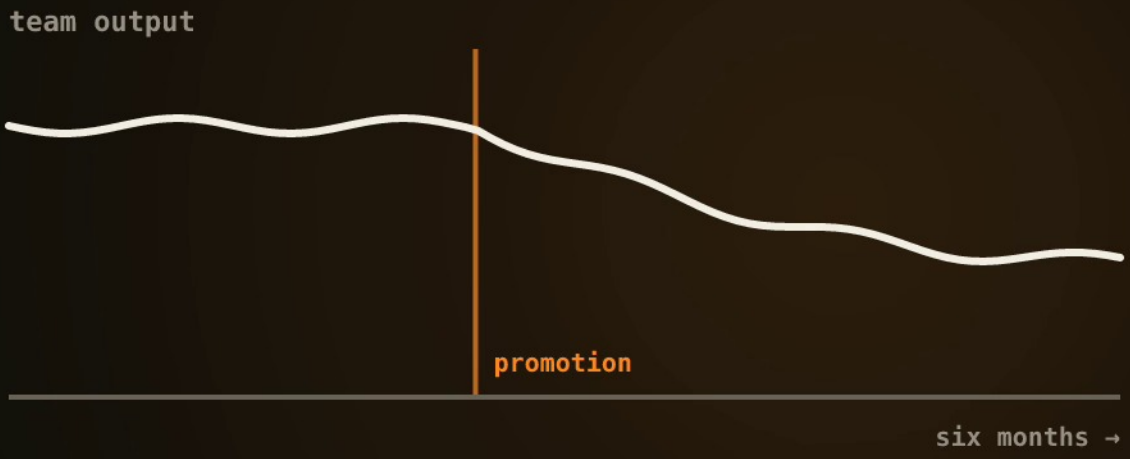
swipe →

Ivan Rykov

01 THE HOOK

# Best engineer, new manager



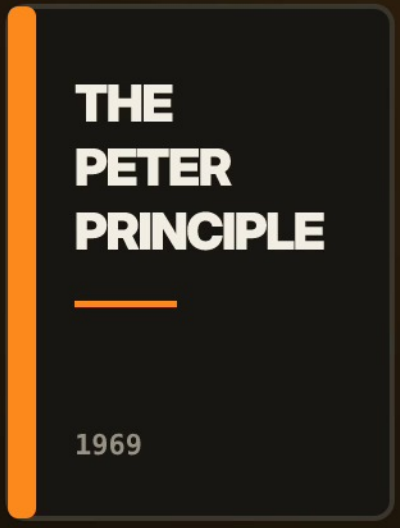




A slower team, and one engineer fewer

This has a name

illustration

# “In a hierarchy, every employee tends to rise to his level of incompetence”

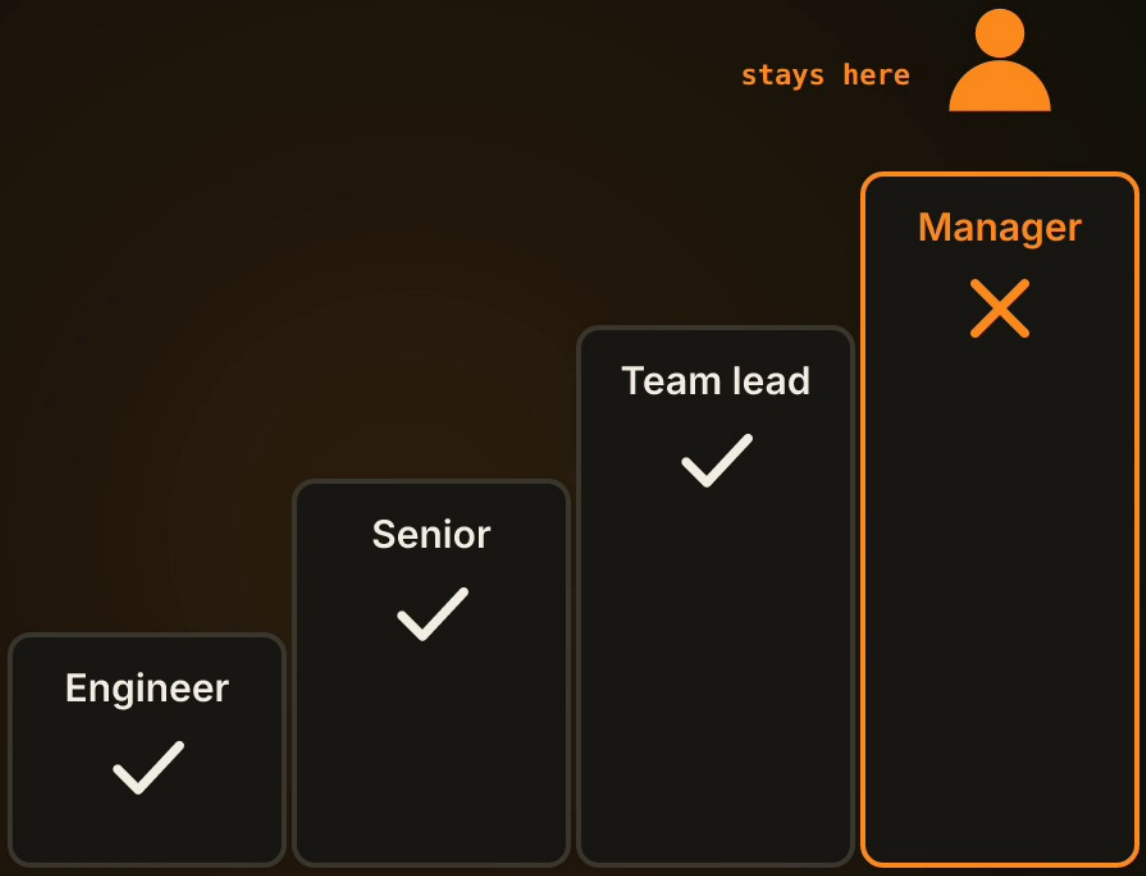



Laurence J. Peter
& Raymond Hull

William Morrow, 1969

written as satire
and read as truth

# Promoted for the job they already do




Each promotion rewards the last job

illustration

04 THE DATA

# Satire, but the data agrees

**53,035** sales workers

214 firms · 2005-2011



1 dot ≈ 500 workers

**1,531** promoted to manager

BENSON, LI & SHUE · 2019

Quarterly Journal of Economics

# Top sellers made weaker bosses

DOUBLE YOUR SALES

**+14.3%**

chance of promotion



DOUBLE THE NEW MANAGER'S OLD SALES

**−7.5%**

sales per team member



A BETTER SIGNAL

**Shared sales**

with colleagues before the promotion

relative changes · an association, not proof · Benson, Li & Shue, 2019

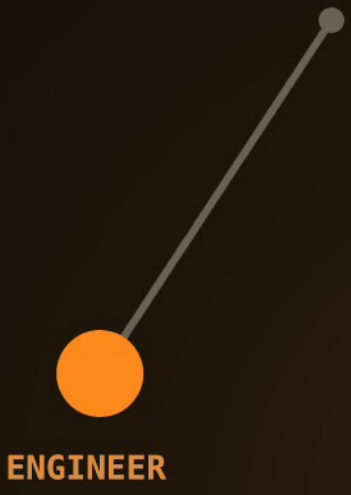
# Two ladders, not one

| TECHNICAL | MANAGEMENT |
| --- | --- |
| Principal | Director |
| Staff | Manager |
| Senior | Team lead |
| Engineer | Engineer |

Try first: tech lead · lead one project

illustration · level names vary by company

# Make the way back safe



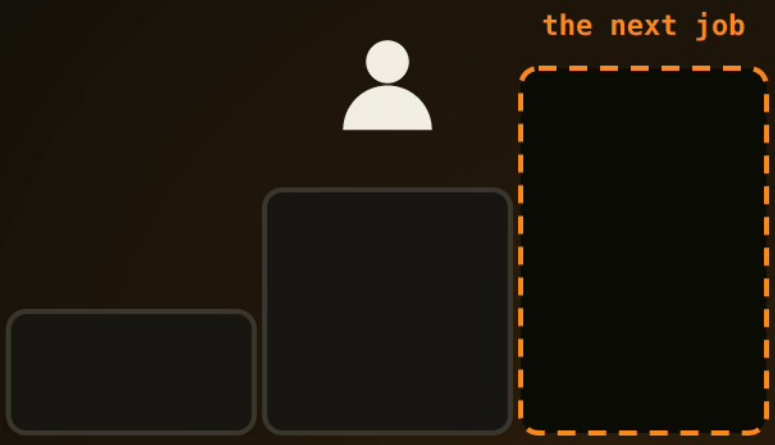

CHARITY MAJORS · THE ENGINEER/MANAGER PENDULUM · 2017

> “Management is not a promotion, management is a change of profession”

charity.wtf, 11 May 2017

## Going back is not a failure

# Promote for the next job




Not for the last one

TAKEAWAY

# Promote for the next job
# Not for the last one

Sources: Peter and Hull, 1969 · Benson, Li and Shue, 2019 · Charity Majors, 2017

next: Gilb's law